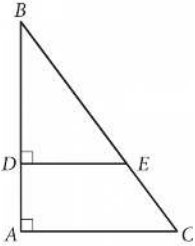


Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Math	Geometry and Trigonometry	Right triangles and trigonometry	Hard

Question



In the figure above, $\tan B = \frac{3}{4}$. If $BC = 15$ and $DA = 4$, what is the length of $\overline{DE}$?

Rationale

The correct answer is 6. Since $\tan B = \frac{3}{4}$, $\triangle ABC$ and $\triangle DBE$ are both similar to 3-4-5 triangles. This means that they are both similar to the right triangle with sides of lengths 3, 4, and 5. Since $BC = 15$, which is 3 times as long as the hypotenuse of the 3-4-5 triangle, the similarity ratio of $\triangle ABC$ to the 3-4-5 triangle is 3:1. Therefore, the length of $\overline{AC}$ (the side opposite to $\angle B$) is $3 \times 3 = 9$, and the length of $\overline{AB}$ (the side adjacent to $\angle B$) is $4 \times 3 = 12$. It is also given that $DA = 4$. Since $AB = DA + DB$ and $AB = 12$, it follows that $DB = 8$, which means that the similarity ratio of $\triangle DBE$ to the 3-4-5 triangle is 2:1 ($\overline{DB}$ is the side adjacent to $\angle B$). Therefore, the length of $\overline{DE}$, which is the side opposite to $\angle B$, is $3 \times 2 = 6$.